

## The sophists and relativism



Alongside the new democracy in Athens came a new legal system, and with it a class of advocates who, for a fee, would argue cases for clients or teach them how to use rhetoric and rational argument. Out of this class emerged a school of philosophers known as sophists, led by Protagoras, who used similar techniques to examine ideas of morality. Central to sophism is the idea (very much a lawyer's stance), that there is more than one side to every argument, and we must take into account the perspective of the people involved.

For instance, the weather in Athens is clement to an Athenian, but seems hot to a visitor from Greenland, and cold to one from Egypt. This idea that there is no absolute truth and that there is only relative, subjective value, is known as relativism, and was summed up by Protagoras as 'man is the measure of all things'. Although this stance seems a reasonable one, the relativist approach does pose problems for moral philosophy: are there *really* no moral absolutes?